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April 20, 2026

COMMITTEE SUBSTITUTE
FOR ENGROSSED
HOUSE BILL NO. 1979

By: Ranson, Waldron, Archer,
Pae, Lawson, Provenzano,
Hefner, Schreiber, Munson,
and Dollens of the House

Hall of the Senate

An Act relating to children; creating the Early Childhood Task Force; providing for task force membership; providing for election of chair and vice chair; permitting the selection of honorary chair; directing task force to provide reports; disallowing certain members from receiving compensation or reimbursement; permitting certain members to claim certain expenses; requiring task force to be subject to the Oklahoma Open Records Act and the Oklahoma Open Meeting Act; providing that task force documents and recommendations shall only be considered advice; providing a vision statement; providing a mission; providing principles the task force is to be guided by; providing tasks for the task force; providing for codification; and providing an effective date.

BE IT ENACTED BY THE PEOPLE OF THE STATE OF OKLAHOMA:

SECTION 1. NEW LAW A new section of law to be codified in the Oklahoma Statutes as Section 390 of Title 10, unless there is created a duplication in numbering, reads as follows:

1 A. There is hereby created the Early Childhood Task Force to
2 study and make recommendations to improve service access to and
3 delivery to families and children and increase the quantity of high-
4 quality early childhood services.

5 B. The task force shall be comprised of eighteen (18) members
6 to be appointed as follows:

7 1. The Director of Human Services, or a designee;

8 2. The State Commissioner of Health, or a designee;

9 3. The Chief Executive Officer of the Oklahoma Department of
10 Commerce, or a designee;

11 4. The Superintendent of Public Instruction, or a designee;

12 5. The Administrator of the Oklahoma Health Care Authority, or
13 a designee;

14 6. A representative of a statewide association representing the
15 business community that is exempt from taxation under Section
16 501(c)(6) of the Internal Revenue Code of 1986, as amended,
17 appointed by the Governor;

18 7. Two child care providers, each of whom is a member of a
19 statewide association representing child care providers, appointed
20 by the Director of Human Services;

21 8. A representative of an Oklahoma parent-child support
22 organization, selected by the Director of the Early Childhood
23 Education Institute of the University of Oklahoma;

1 9. The Executive Director of Oklahoma Partnership for School
2 Readiness, or a designee;

3 10. A representative of a statewide association that advocates
4 for early childhood education, appointed by the Superintendent of
5 Public Instruction;

6 11. A Senator, appointed by the President Pro Tempore of the
7 Senate;

8 12. A Representative, appointed by the Speaker of the House of
9 Representatives;

10 13. A director of a public school early childhood program,
11 appointed by the Superintendent of Public Instruction;

12 14. A representative responsible for programs under Part C of
13 the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA), appointed by
14 the State Commissioner of Health;

15 15. A representative from Oklahoma State University's
16 Department of Human Development and Family Science, appointed by the
17 Dean of the College of Education and Human Sciences of Oklahoma
18 State University;

19 16. A pediatric specialist appointed by the Chair of the
20 Department of Pediatrics of the University of Oklahoma College of
21 Medicine; and

22 17. A representative of a statewide professional association
23 representing the workforce for infant and early childhood mental
24

1 health services, appointed by the Commissioner of Mental Health and
2 Substance Abuse Services.

3 C. The Early Childhood Task Force shall elect a chair and vice
4 chair, or co-chairs, from the task force's membership, and the chair
5 or co-chairs shall establish rules for the task force's meetings and
6 the conducting of business. Upon the absence or vacancy of the
7 chair, the vice chair shall serve as chair in an acting capacity.

8 D. An honorary chair may be selected to serve in a ceremonial
9 capacity. The honorary chair shall not serve as a voting member of
10 the task force but may engage with the work of the task force in an
11 advisory role or in a manner deemed appropriate by the chair or co-
12 chairs.

13 E. The task force shall develop and electronically submit an
14 initial report to the President Pro Tempore of the Senate and the
15 Speaker of the House of Representatives by November 2027 and a final
16 report by November 2028.

17 F. Members shall receive no compensation or reimbursement for
18 expenses and shall serve voluntarily. Officers or employees of
19 state agencies who are appointed to the task force as part of their
20 duties shall be authorized to participate on the task force and may
21 claim subsistence, allowance, mileage, or associated expenses from
22 their respective agency budgets as permitted by law.

23 G. The task force shall be subject to the Oklahoma Open Records
24 Act and the Oklahoma Open Meeting Act.

1 H. Plans, reports, or recommendations of any nature adopted by
2 the task force shall be considered advice to the Legislature and
3 shall not be construed as official policies, positions, or
4 interpretations of laws, rules, or regulations by any department or
5 agency of state government, nor shall any such department or agency
6 be bound in any manner to consider such advice when conducting its
7 advisory and regulatory affairs.

8 I. The task force shall be guided by the following vision
9 statement: Oklahoma children, especially those between zero (0) and
10 five (5) years of age, deserve healthy childhoods that are supported
11 by a robust early childhood system which improves outcomes and
12 effectively provides high-quality early care and education, improves
13 and enhances school readiness, adapts to the needs of families and
14 communities, and is equitably accessible to all communities across
15 the state.

16 J. The task force shall work toward the mission of creating a
17 framework for a more efficient and effective governance structure
18 for early childhood programming, such as a coordinated,
19 consolidated, or new independent agency.

20 K. The task force's work shall be guided by a commitment to the
21 following principles:

22 1. Children, family, and community well-being shall be centered
23 throughout the Early Childhood Task Force's work;
24

1 2. Efforts shall be focused on maximizing efficiencies to
2 reduce the administrative burdens on families and improve access to
3 early childhood services through the creation of a new governance
4 structure;

5 3. Any possible consolidation of early childhood services shall
6 be informed by what families and communities say are wanted and
7 needed;

8 4. Access to programs and services shall be equitable and
9 available to all children and families regardless of socioeconomic
10 status or geographic location;

11 5. Intentional focus shall be placed on developing strategies
12 to reach families and young children in health care, early
13 education, and care deserts or furthest from opportunity and
14 existing resources;

15 6. Access to affordable and quality health care, nutrition,
16 early education and care, mental health, home visiting, early
17 intervention, support for families, early learning, and other
18 services in the critical prenatal to five-year age period will
19 decisively impact academic success, economic development
20 opportunities, and the prosperity of Oklahoma;

21 7. Efforts shall be made to use data-informed approaches and
22 explore better ways to develop shared data systems;

23 8. Work shall focus on strengthening and expanding the early
24 education and care delivery system already in use in Oklahoma;

1 9. Alignment across sectors and state agencies shall increase
2 capacity, maximize funding, and create a more streamlined delivery
3 of services;

4 10. The importance of growing a well-educated and well-
5 supported early childhood workforce shall remain at the forefront
6 and be informed by the task force's work;

7 11. While focusing on advancing the delivery system, work shall
8 highlight the importance of defining quality care and expanding
9 capacity and access to create a greater quantity of quality
10 services;

11 12. To incentivize innovation and respond to family needs,
12 communities must be empowered to develop local, community-based
13 solutions that take a whole-child and whole-family approach in
14 responding to needs;

15 13. To ensure holistic childhood well-being and improve health
16 outcomes, there must be alignment between state efforts to improve
17 early learning and care and existing prenatal and maternal health
18 initiatives; and

19 14. Strengthening early childhood developmental health is vital
20 to ensuring that children are prepared to achieve academic success
21 and are prepared for lifelong learning.

22 L. The task force's duties shall include:

23 1. Conducting an analysis of the current early childhood
24 delivery system in Oklahoma and how it is financed with specific

1 focus on gaps, inefficiencies, and redundancies. This work should
2 focus on how creating a new governance structure for early childhood
3 services could overcome these challenges and improve how care is
4 delivered, accessed, and funded. This analysis must specifically
5 include:

- 6 a. a review of current early childhood programs and
7 policies dispersed between the Department of Human
8 Services, State Department of Health, Department of
9 Mental Health and Substance Abuse Services, Oklahoma
10 Department of Commerce, Oklahoma Health Care
11 Authority, and State Department of Education. The
12 review should pay special attention to where current
13 statutory authority over certain operations exists and
14 where possible areas of redundancy occur,
- 15 b. a review of how current funding systems blend and
16 various funding opportunities, with special attention
17 as to how funding streams are currently utilized for
18 early childhood programs that are housed across
19 departments. This fiscal review should map the routes
20 all private, public, federal, and state funding
21 streams take from funding authority to program
22 application,
- 23 c. a review of how Oklahoma might integrate existing
24 programming into a consolidated delivery system and

1 what needs might exist for new programming that the
2 state currently lacks,

3 d. recommendations on how cross-agency collaboration and
4 partnerships can be fostered to develop a whole-of-
5 government approach to strengthening the delivery of
6 early childhood services, specifically ensuring that
7 data infrastructure is integrated across agencies,
8 accounts for both qualitative and quantitative
9 methods, and can be widely utilized by multiple state
10 agencies,

11 e. recommendations on how a new governance structure
12 might maximize efficiencies for early childhood
13 providers and their workforce. This work should
14 determine how licensing, workforce development and
15 support, and facility review can be improved to
16 eliminate barriers to entry for providers and
17 professionals. This should also include a review of
18 current regulatory structures that complicate the
19 process of entering the early childhood sector,

20 f. recommendations on how a new governance structure can
21 strengthen the existing health care workforce to
22 better support the development of young children and
23 well-being of mothers through improved access to
24 comprehensive and preventive care. This should also

1 include a review of how to secure improved health
2 outcomes for children, financial sustainability of
3 delivery models, and robust workforce pipelines, and
4 g. an analysis of key lessons learned from states already
5 advancing consolidated systems of early childhood
6 governance to inform Oklahoma's own process;

7 2. Conducting a series of stakeholder engagement opportunities
8 to elicit feedback on the current early childhood governance
9 structure and better understand the needs of parents, families,
10 providers, and businesses;

11 3. Following the engagement of stakeholders, conducting a
12 review that synthesizes feedback received from families, providers,
13 community leaders, and the business sector. This review shall
14 include recommendations on how the state delivery system and
15 governance model can be improved to respond to family and community
16 needs. It shall also include recommendations for how the state can
17 better engage with parents, families, and communities on a regular
18 basis to ensure family voice is centered in the work of state
19 agencies;

20 4. Drafting a proposed transition plan to ensure the continuous
21 operation of state services upon the creation of a new governance
22 structure for early childhood. This plan shall:

23 a. include detailed recommendations for what programs and
24 services should remain in their current place or

1 transition into a new governance structure. Each
2 recommendation shall consider the challenges and
3 benefits of moving programs,

4 b. focus on movement between agencies and how
5 collaboration can be strengthened with nonexecutive
6 agencies. It shall also include recommendations for
7 any necessary interagency agreements,

8 c. include a review of what additional funding, if any,
9 and resources, if any, might be needed to transition
10 to a new governance structure effectively and
11 efficiently, and

12 d. provide recommended goals and metrics for the new
13 entity to strive toward once operational; and

14 5. Drafting proposed legislation that creates a new governance
15 structure that oversees Oklahoma's early childhood education and
16 care programs.

17 SECTION 2. This act shall become effective November 1, 2026.

18 COMMITTEE REPORT BY: COMMITTEE ON HEALTH AND HUMAN SERVICES
19 April 20, 2026 - DO PASS AS AMENDED BY CS
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